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What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **A federal judge blocked** Kroger from acquiring Albertsons, siding with the FTC, which said the \$20 billion supermarket merger would erode competition and raise prices for consumers. **A1**

◆ **Walgreens is in talks** to sell itself to a private-equity firm in a deal that would take the pharmacy chain off the public market after its shares have been sliding for nearly a decade. **A1**

◆ **Trump picked** Andrew Ferguson to lead the FTC, a move that could see a shift from antitrust enforcement to cracking down on tech firms accused of stifling political expression. **A2**

◆ **GM scrapped its Cruise** robotaxi program, citing the time and costs needed to scale the business and rising competition from competitors. **B1**

◆ **Bitcoin investors** celebrating the cryptocurrency's surge to a record say the rally will continue because of the limit to the number of bitcoins that can ever be created. **B1**

◆ **Major U.S. stock indexes** declined after wavering between positive and negative territory, with the S&P 500, Dow and Nasdaq all slipping 0.3%. **B13**

◆ **Sony shares climbed** to a record, driven by growing hopes for its games segment and other entertainment businesses. **B4**

◆ **VW and labor leaders** will meet next week for more talks after they failed to agree on how to proceed with the automaker's planned cost cuts. **B3**

◆ **U.S. investor Todd Boehly**, is in talks to potentially help fund the acquisition of Britain's Daily Telegraph newspaper by the owner and publisher of the New York Sun. **B3**

World-Wide

◆ **A defiant Luigi Mangione**, shackled and struggling with officers on his way into court in Hollidaysburg, Pa., opposed being sent to New York City to stand trial in the shooting death of UnitedHealth executive Brian Thompson. **A1, A2**

◆ **Syrian rebel group Hayat Tahrir al-Sham** said it had nearly secured Damascus and tapped political ally Mohammed al-Bashir to form a transitional government. **A8**

◆ **Israel targeted Syria's** naval and other military assets as part of its campaign to destroy weapons left behind by the toppled Assad regime. **A7**

◆ **Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu** took the stand to testify in his long-running corruption trial even as he manages a multifront war. **A7**

◆ **China massed dozens** of navy and coast guard vessels in what appears to be the largest maritime exercises targeting Taiwan and the broader Western Pacific since 1996. **A9**

◆ **South Korea's former** defense minister was arrested for his alleged collusion with President Yoon Suk Yeol to impose martial law last week. **A8**

◆ **A global test of** adult know-how that measures job readiness and problem-solving among workers in industrialized countries showed Americans falling behind. **A3**

◆ **Brazilian President Lula da Silva** was recovering in intensive care after undergoing emergency brain surgery to ease bleeding after a fall he suffered at home in October. **A9**

◆ **Died: Nikki Giovanni**, 81, celebrity poet, author, educator and public speaker. **A6**

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Kroger-Albertsons Deal Blocked

Judge sides with FTC, which argued merger would have killed competition

By DAVE MICHAELS AND PATRICK THOMAS

A federal judge blocked Kroger from acquiring Albertsons, siding with Biden administration antitrust enforcers who said the \$20 billion supermarket merger would erode competition and raise

prices for consumers.

U.S. District Judge Adrienne Nelson agreed with the Federal Trade Commission's argument that Kroger would become the dominant player in traditional supermarkets if allowed to add nearly 2,000 stores by taking over Albertsons. Nelson rejected the companies' counterargument that selling 579 stores to C&S Wholesale Grocers would replace the lost competition.

"Evidence shows that defendants engage in substantial head-to-head competition and

the proposed merger would remove that competition," Nelson wrote in the ruling.

The decision is a milestone for the FTC under the Biden administration, whose chair, Lina Khan, has waged legal battles to stop megadeals rather than accept companies' proposed fixes to address competition concerns.

For the companies, the decision is a blow to a deal that executives said is critical for competing against bigger retail powers like Walmart and Amazon. Attorneys for Kroger and

Albertsons previously said they would likely abandon the deal if the judge sided with the FTC.

An FTC spokesman said the ruling "protects competition in the grocery market, which will prevent prices from rising even more."

Representatives for Kroger and Albertsons said the companies were disappointed by the decision and that they are weighing their options. Kroger shares closed up 5.1% on Tuesday while Albertsons stock dropped 2.3%.

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Walgreens Is in Talks To Go Private In Buyout

Dealmaker Sycamore expected to sell off pieces of pharmacy chain, seek partners

Walgreens is in talks to sell itself to a private-equity firm in a deal that would take the pharmacy chain off the public market after its shares have been on a downward slide for nearly a decade.

By Cara Lombardo, Lauren Thomas and Anna Wilde Mathews

Walgreens Boots Alliance and Sycamore Partners have been discussing a deal that could be completed early next year, assuming talks don't fall apart, people familiar with the matter said.

Walgreens's market value reached a peak of over \$100 billion in 2015 but had since shrunk to around \$7.5 billion as of Monday. Mounting pressures on its pharmacy and retail businesses had helped send its shares down nearly 70% this year before The Wall Street Journal reported on the deal talks on Tuesday.

Walgreens's shares closed up 18% after the report, giving the company a market value of around \$9 billion. That marked the biggest one-day jump in the company's history.

Any deal would be a big bite for Sycamore, a New York-based firm that specializes in retail and consumer investments and more recently is better known for smaller deals. The firm would likely sell off pieces of the business or work with partners, one of the people said.

Walgreens spent more than 12 decades scaling to become one of America's most ubiquitous retailers, with its stores

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◆ **Medical-apparel maker Figs** gets takeover bid... **B5**



A rebel fighter pored over personal souvenirs of ousted Syrian leader Bashar al-Assad in his ransacked palace on Tuesday.

Inside Assad's Palace: Anxiety Pills, Looted Offices, a Bunker War Room

By JARED MALSIN

DAMASCUS, Syria—Rebel fighters and civilians strolled through the grounds of Bashar al-Assad's presidential palace on Tuesday, stepping on shredded posters of the former dictator who had fled to Russia days earlier.

In Assad's abandoned office, his desk and floor were lit-

tered with books and papers: a history of the Russian military, a map of northeastern Syria, a biography of himself. Strips of benzodiazepine antianxiety pills sat in their packaging on the desktop.

On one of the yellowed windows overlooking Damascus, someone had spray-painted, "God damn your soul, Hafez," a reference to Bashar's father,

Hafez al-Assad, who ruled Syria for some three decades before his son inherited power.

The palace was a glimpse into the last days of a dictator who for more than a decade used torture, bombings and chemical weapons in a war to suppress a rebellion against him, which began during the Arab Spring protests in 2011.

In recent days, demonstra-

tors have swarmed into Umayyad Square in the center of the capital, posing with rebel fighters holding assault rifles

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◆ **Israel strikes Syria's navy, military arsenal**..... **A7**

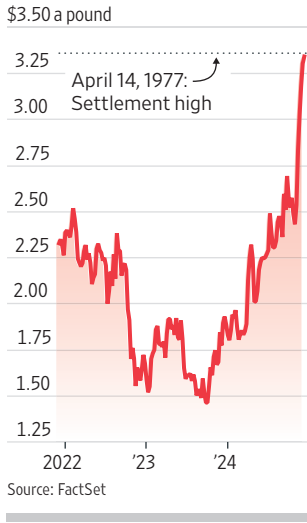
◆ **Europe asks if refugees should go home**..... **A7**

◆ **Rebels rush to impose order in Damascus**..... **A8**

Coffee Prices Set Record

Coffee futures prices hit new highs Tuesday, pushing past a record set in April 1977. **B1**

Arabica coffee futures price



Source: FactSet

Defiant UnitedHealth Murder Suspect Fights New York's Extradition Efforts

HOLLIDAYSBURG, Pa.—A defiant Luigi Mangione, shackled and struggling with officers on his way into court here on Tuesday, opposed be-

By Kris Maher, James Fanelli and Caitlin Ostroff

ing sent to New York City to stand trial in the shooting death of UnitedHealth executive Brian Thompson.

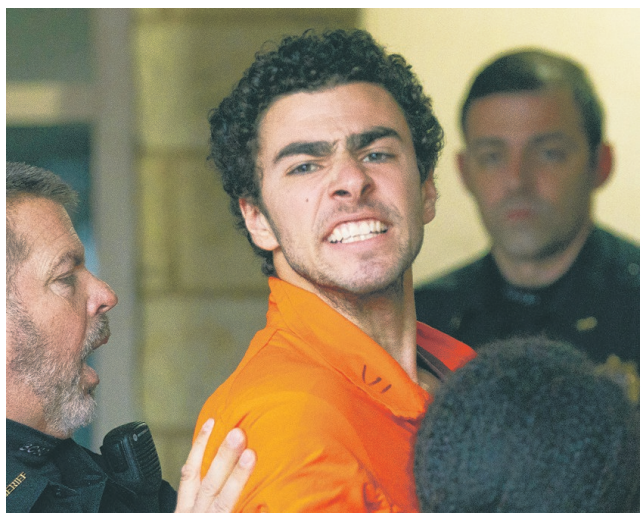
"It's an insult to the intelligence of the American people and their lived experience," the Ivy League graduate shouted to onlookers as officers muscled him into the Blair County Courthouse before his hearing. It was un-

clear to what he was referring. Once inside the courtroom, he sat in an orange jumpsuit next to his lawyer with deputy sheriffs and officers flanking him.

His lawyer, Thomas Dickey, told a Pennsylvania judge that his client wouldn't waive his right to extradition proceedings. The attorney, based in nearby Altoona, also sought bail for his client, who investigators said gunned down Thompson in Midtown Manhattan last week and then fled New York.

Mangione, 26 years old, Please turn to page A2

◆ **Health-insurance CEOs** fear for their safety..... **A2**



Scan a code on A2 for video of Luigi Mangione shouting at a crowd outside the courthouse in Pennsylvania on Tuesday.

In China's Aging Cities, Young Flee, Babies Are Few

Fushun, where roughly a third of the population is 60 or above, offers a view of the nation's future

By YOKO KUBOTA AND LIYAN QI

FUSHUN, China—This rust-belt hub helped fuel China's economic rise. Now, it offers a view of China's future—in which eroding growth collides with a ballooning elderly population and a shortfall in babies.

Once vibrating with energy, Fushun is a city slowly going to sleep. Most of its coal mines and refineries have closed. Half its young people have left. Its pension coffers are heavily in the red, with roughly a third of its population 60 or above.

Last year, only 5,541 babies were born in the city of 1.7 million. By comparison, Michi-

gan's Wayne County, which includes Detroit and has a similar-size population, logged more than 20,000 births.

Signs of aging are everywhere. Bus stops carry cemetery ads. Taxis advertise dental implants—\$200 a tooth or \$1,680 for "half a mouth."

On a city bus one recent weekend, dozens of elderly chatted about retirement and doted on the handful of small children on board, making sure the little ones got seats. The bus passed empty apartment buildings that once bustled with mine workers' families and stopped near a former elementary school

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This Christmas, Give the Gift Of Someone Else's Mail

Mystery packages have become popular, but things can get weird in a hurry

By BEN ASHWELL

When her boss said he didn't want a gift for his birthday, Susan Shuwei-hat didn't just ignore him. She ordered a box of unclaimed mail and personally delivered it to his home. What happened next could have landed Shuwei-hat in the HR hall of shame.

As she and her boss's wife sat down in his front room, they watched while he opened the box and began unwrapping the smaller packages inside. First came a piece of fe-

male lingerie. Then came a gift that made the first one look as innocent as a cookbook: a sex toy for men called a fleshlight.

Shuwei-hat got lucky. After a few seconds of uncomfortable silence, her boss laughed. Then his wife joined in. Soon they were all chuckling as they looked up what a fleshlight is. (Advice: Use a personal device.)

"They thought I'd set the whole thing up," said Shuwei-hat, who in fact was just as surprised as they were.

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